



Budget Smartphone (under 20K)

Value champions!

One of the most popular and jam-packed categories this year, and practically every year before that, the budget smartphones showed us the best possible balance between price and performance. Like last year, this year too we had to stretch our price limit for the budget smartphone category to ₹20,000 so we could accommodate some of the most popular phones in the upper echelon of the budget category. There were several key launches in the sub-₹20k price range which saw a trickle-down effect as more and more flagship features made it to the affordable smartphones. From 120 Hz AMOLED screens to 108 MP cameras to powerful SoCs, the budget category this year was packed to the brim with phones that are great to fulfil your gaming and entertainment needs.

Winner: iQOO Z3

The iQOO Z3 swept the crown for the best budget smartphone of 2021 and offers a significant bump in performance in comparison to the Redmi Note 10 Pro Max which ends up being this year's runner-up. iQOO puts performance above everything else which is why when it comes to raw performance we saw the Z3 gets really high scores in CPU and GPU performance benchmarks. The general day-to-day performance of the iQOO Z3 remained lag-free and it can handle more than just a couple of rounds of your favourite battle royale game. It also surpassed its counterparts in the battery life department and has one of the fastest battery charging speeds in this price range. That said, the iQOO Z3 has its downsides as it misses the mark in camera performance, lacks stereo speakers and has a dated waterdrop notch that doesn't look in line with a phone released in 2021. Nevertheless, the Zero1 Awards is all about performance and the iQOO Z3 takes the crown.



iQOO Z3

Price: ₹19,999



Redmi Note 10 Pro Max

Price: ₹19,999



Samsung Galaxy M12

Price: ₹11,499

Runner Up: Redmi Note 10 Pro Max

The Redmi Note 10 Pro Max is the most versatile smartphone that you can get for under ₹20,000. It only loses some marks in performance where it is bested by the iQOO Z3 but gains significant advantage with its powerful and feature-rich 108 MP quad-camera array, a beautiful and unparalleled AMOLED display that supports upto 120 Hz refresh rate, stereo speakers and a larger battery to boot. That said, the performance of this phone remained a downside which had an impact on its shelf life. Also, it's not 5G compatible, which gives way to the iQOO Z3!

Best Buy: Samsung Galaxy M12

Not everyone can or wants to spend truckloads of money on their smartphones. This is where the Samsung Galaxy M12, our best buy choice for the budget range comes in. The Galaxy M12 has a reasonable feature set featuring a 90 Hz refresh rate IPS display, quad cameras on the back and a whopping 6,000 mAh battery that is sure to last you two days. Having said that, don't expect too much from the Galaxy M12 as it offers the basic minimum that's expected from a budget phone launching in 2021.

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